

CHAPTER 8

The Sermon at Benaras

NCERT Exercise Solutions

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✨ Try each question yourself first, then check the answer. 💡 answers are samples: write your own.

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⭐ Let's Begin

1 (a) **In the lesson 'The Sermon at Benaras' you were asked to find out the meaning of 'sermon'. The meanings are: • a talk on a religious or moral subject • a long or monotonous piece of admonition or caution or a warning, a lecture.**

Discuss with your classmates the context to which the present text belongs.

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

The present text belongs to the **first context**: 'a talk on a religious or moral subject'.

The Buddha preached his first sermon at Benares. Through the story of Kisa Gotami he teaches that death is common to all and that the wise do not grieve. It is a moral and spiritual talk, not a scolding.

1 (b) **What could be the examples for the different context according to you?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- **Religious/moral talk:** a priest's sermon in a church, a guru's pravachan, the Sermon on the Mount by Jesus Christ, a talk on honesty in the morning assembly.

- **Lecture/warning (negative sense):** a mother's long 'sermon' about finishing homework on time, a father's lecture about using the mobile phone too much, a teacher's repeated warning about coming late.

1 (c) **When your parents or elders say something, you say, "Oh, not again!" When do you say so and why?**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

I say "Oh, not again!" when my parents repeat the same advice again and again, for example, 'Sleep early', 'Don't watch so much TV' or 'Study for your exams'.

I say so because I have heard it many times and it feels like a long lecture. But I know they say it because they care for me and want the best for me.

2 **Read the poem 'Death Is Nothing At All' by Canon Henry Scott Holland (delivered as part of a sermon in 1910) in the context of 'The Sermon at Benaras'.**

After reading the poem, discuss in groups of four and list the similarities and differences between 'The Sermon at Benaras' and 'Death Is Nothing At All'. For example the theme, the situation, the philosophy of the two speakers etc.

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Similarities

- Both are **sermons** given by religious men (the Buddha; a priest of St. Paul's Cathedral).
- Theme of both is **death and grief**. Both ask people not to weep and grieve too much.
- Both bring comfort and peace of mind to those who have lost a loved one.

Differences

Point	The Sermon at Benaras	Death Is Nothing At All
Speaker	The Buddha speaks to a grieving mother	The dead person himself speaks to his loved ones
Situation	Kisa Gotami has lost her only son	A family has lost a dear member
View of death	Death is common to all and cannot be avoided; 'all are subject to death'	Death is 'nothing at all', only 'slipping away into the next room'

Philosophy	Accept death; give up selfish grief to find peace	Life goes on unchanged; we will meet again 'just round the corner'
Style	Prose, story with a lesson	Poem, personal and gentle

⭐ Reading Comprehension · Text I

Q.1 **According to His Holiness the Dalai Lama, what should we do if we want a happier humanity?**

✔ ANSWER

If we want a happier humanity and a happy world, we must **tackle the root of the problem**, which lies within the human mind. Our intelligence should be joined with human affection and compassion.

Q.2 **Where does the ultimate cause of the problem lie?**

✔ ANSWER

The ultimate cause of the problem lies **within the human mind**. The economy and political power are also causes, but not the main one.

Q.3 **"What I call human feeling, then 'it' is very useful." What is 'it' referred to here?**

✔ ANSWER

Here 'it' refers to **intelligence**. Intelligence is very useful when it is accompanied with human affection and compassion (human feeling).

Q.4 **Why does the Dalai Lama say that proper motivation is important?**

✔ ANSWER

He says so because **every human action**, verbal or physical, even minor actions, **has some motivation**. Proper motivation leads to proper development, so good actions come only from good motivation.

Q.5 **Why is there a requirement of correlation between the intention of an individual and the interest of society?**

✔ ANSWER

Because if society's moral values and standards of behaviour become negative, **each of us will suffer**. So the intentions of an individual are closely related to the interests of society; good individuals make a good society.

Q.6 **What does His Holiness the Dalai Lama mean by “spiritual development”?**

✔ ANSWER

By ‘spiritual development’ he does not mean anything religious. He simply means **having a good and compassionate heart**.

Q.7 **A compassionate heart brings — (a) ___ (b) ___ (c) ___**

✔ ANSWER

(a) inner strength

(b) less fear and less doubt

(c) happiness and an open mind, thus making more friends in society

⭐ Reading Comprehension · Text II (The Ballad of Father Gilligan)

Q.1 **Why did Father Gilligan cry “my body spake, not I”?**

✔ ANSWER

Being very tired, he complained, “I have no rest, nor joy, nor peace, for people die and die.” At once he felt sorry and asked God to forgive him. He said it was his **tired body** that complained, **not his true self**, which still wanted to serve people.

Q.2 **“The moth-hour of eve”, “the moth hour went” and “the moths came once more” establish a link. They suggest —**

(a) the movement of moths.

(b) the passage of time.

(c) the actions of Father Gilligan.

✔ ANSWER

(b) the passage of time. The moth-hour of evening came, went, and came again, showing that a whole night and day passed while the priest slept.

Q.3 **Why did the poet say that the priest “rode with little care”? Does it mean that the old priest, Peter Gilligan, had no care for the safety of the horse and people on the way? What did he not care about?**

✔ ANSWER

No, it does not mean he did not care for the horse or people. He was in a great hurry to reach the sick man, thinking he had died because the priest slept. So he rode fast ‘as he never rode’ by rocky lane and fen, **not caring about his own comfort and safety** or the rough path.

Q.4 **How did the priest feel when he heard that the sick man was dead? (Choose the correct option.)**

(a) He was frustrated and amazed.

(b) He was ashamed and annoyed.

(c) He was full of grief and self-condemnation.

✔ ANSWER

(c) He was full of grief and self-condemnation. He ‘in grief swayed to and fro’, blaming himself for sleeping while the man died.

Q.5 **Why did Father Gilligan kneel down when he heard the sick man’s wife say “When you were gone...”?**

✔ ANSWER

The wife said a priest had come and the man died ‘as merry as a bird’. Father Gilligan understood that **God had sent an angel** in his place while he slept. He knelt down to **thank God** for His kindness.

Q.6 **How did God help when “the least of things” was in need?**

✔ ANSWER

God, who has the planets in His care, had pity on the tired old priest asleep on a chair (‘the least of things’). He **sent one of His great angels down** to comfort the dying man and give him the last rites in the priest’s place.

⭐ Vocabulary

1 **Antonyms for the words in the text 'The Sermon at Benaras' are given below. Find the words and fill in the blanks.**

(a) unfit (b) joy (c) contentment (d) found (e) cheered (f) lively (g) calm

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

(a) unfit — **befitted** ('lived ... as befitted royalty')

(b) joy — **grief** / sorrow

(c) contentment — **complaint** / desolation

(d) found — **lost**

(e) cheered — **lamenting** / pitied

(f) lively — **weary** / dead

(g) calm — **troubled** / afflicted

2 **Use a dictionary to find out four words each having the meaning nearest to the ones given below.**

Example: wander — stroll, dawdle, drift, roam

(a) vow (b) preach (c) preserve (d) awaken (e) enlighten (f) reign

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

(a) vow — promise, pledge, swear, oath

(b) preach — teach, lecture, sermonise, advocate

(c) preserve — protect, save, conserve, maintain

(d) awaken — wake, rouse, arouse, stir

(e) enlighten — educate, inform, illuminate, instruct

(f) reign — rule, govern, prevail, dominate

⭐ Grammar · Reported Speech

1 **Read the passage ("Kisa Gotami had an only son, ... a child, husband, parent or friend.") from the text, 'The Sermon at Benaras'. Rewrite the paragraphs changing the direct speech into reported speech.**

✔ ANSWER

Kisa Gotami had an only son, and he died. In her grief she carried the dead child to all her neighbours, asking them for medicine, and the people said that **she had lost her senses** and that **the boy was dead**.

At length, Kisa Gotami met a man who replied to her request that **he could not give her medicine for her child, but he knew a physician who could**.

The girl **requested him to tell her who it was**. The man replied that **she should go to Sakyamuni, the Buddha**.

Kisa Gotami went to the Buddha and, addressing him as Lord and Master, **cried out to him to give her the medicine that would cure her boy**.

The Buddha answered that **he wanted a handful of mustard-seed**. When the girl in her joy promised to procure it, the Buddha added that **the mustard-seed must be taken from a house where no one had lost a child, husband, parent or friend**.

2 **Read the story given below. Change the direct speech into reported speech and rewrite the story. Use the reporting verbs given above wherever necessary.**

It is said, "It is not how much we have, but how much we enjoy that makes happiness." Being happy does not require everything to be good but an eye to see good in everything. One day a crow saw a swan. "This swan is so white," he thought, "and I am so black. This swan must be the happiest bird in the world." The swan replied, "I was feeling that I was the happiest bird around. But I think the parrot is the happiest bird as it has two colours." The crow then approached the parrot. The parrot said, "I have only two colours, but the peacock has multiple colours." The crow then visited a peacock in the zoo. "Dear peacock," the crow said, "you are so beautiful. Every day, thousands of

people come to see you. You are the happiest bird on the planet." The peacock said, "I always thought that I was the most beautiful and happy bird on the planet. But I am entrapped in this zoo. I have realised that the crow is the only bird not kept in a cage, and could happily roam everywhere."

✔ ANSWER

It is said that it is not how much we have, but how much we enjoy that makes happiness. Being happy does not require everything to be good but an eye to see good in everything.

One day a crow saw a swan. He thought that **that swan was so white and he was so black**. He thought that **the swan must be the happiest bird in the world**.

When the crow told the swan this, the swan replied that **she had been feeling that she was the happiest bird around**, but **she thought the parrot was the happiest bird as it had two colours**.

The crow then approached the parrot. The parrot said that **she had only two colours, but the peacock had multiple colours**.

The crow then visited a peacock in the zoo. Addressing him as 'dear peacock', the crow **told him that he was so beautiful**. He **added that every day thousands of people came to see him** and **exclaimed that he was the happiest bird on the planet**.

The peacock **replied that he had always thought that he was the most beautiful and happy bird on the planet**, but **he was entrapped in that zoo**. He **explained that he had realised that the crow was the only bird not kept in a cage**, and could happily roam everywhere.

⭐ Editing

1 **There are some omissions in the paragraph given below. Edit the paragraph, use suitable prepositions and words.**

The Wild Geese: One day, Prince Siddhartha was going the royal gardens on his way the river. A flock wild geese passed overhead. Devadatta, the Prince's cousin, shot arrow into their midst one of the geese fell. It was wounded and fell just front of Siddhartha. His heart was filled compassion when he saw poor bird bleeding profusely. He lifted it and he drew the arrow very carefully from its body. He took the bird with him. Devadatta sent a messenger claim the bird. But Siddhartha refused to give it. He said that belonged to him because he had saved its life. It did not belong to Devadutta who had tried to kill.

✔ ANSWER

One day, Prince Siddhartha was going **through** the royal gardens on his way **to** the river. A flock **of** wild geese passed overhead. Devadatta, the Prince's cousin, shot **an** arrow into their midst **and** one of the geese fell. It was wounded and fell just **in** front of Siddhartha. His heart was filled **with** compassion when he saw **the** poor bird bleeding profusely. He lifted it and he drew the arrow very carefully from its body. He took the bird with him. Devadatta sent a messenger **to** claim the bird. But Siddhartha refused to give it. He said that **it** belonged to him because he had saved its life. It did not belong to Devadutta who had tried to kill **it**.

Omission	Word added
going ___ the royal gardens	through
on his way ___ the river	to
A flock ___ wild geese	of
shot ___ arrow	an
into their midst ___ one of the geese fell	and
just ___ front of	in
filled ___ compassion	with
saw ___ poor bird	the
a messenger ___ claim	to
He said that ___ belonged	it
tried to kill ___	it

⭐ Listening (Sanchi Stupa)

(a) Which Buddhist monument is referred to here and what does it portray?

✔ ANSWER

The **Sanchi Stupa**, on a hilltop in Sanchi town, Madhya Pradesh, is referred to here. It portrays **Buddhist art and sculpture**.

(b) Who are the people who visit this Stupa throughout the year?

✔ ANSWER

Thousands of visitors come round the year, including **national and foreign tourists, archaeologists and historians**, among others.

(c) In which period the Stupa was built, and who commissioned it?

✔ ANSWER

It was built during the **Mauryan period**. It was commissioned in the third century BCE by **Emperor Ashoka**.

(d) Where is the central chamber in the Stupa? What is kept inside it?

✔ ANSWER

The central chamber is inside the **huge hemispherical dome** of the Stupa. The **relics of Lord Buddha** are kept in it.

(e) **What structures were added to the huge hemisphere in first century BCE?**

✔ ANSWER

Four ornamental gateways (toranas) facing the four directions and a **balustrade** surrounding the stupa were added in the first century BCE.

(f) **The toranas are decorated with: (Tick the right answer)**

(a) stone ornaments

(b) events of Lord Buddha's life

(c) Lord Buddha's relics

(d) symbolic depiction of Lord Buddha as throne, wheel, footprints, etc.

✔ ANSWER

(b) events of Lord Buddha's life ✓ — the sculptures on the toranas are decorative illustrations of events of the Buddha's life, explained in the Jataka tales. (In these scenes the Buddha is shown through symbols like thrones, wheels and footprints, so (d) is also linked.)

⭐ Speaking

1 **Everyone has some problem or other, and they grieve in unique ways. Discuss with your friend and note down—**

• what could be the possible reasons for someone's grief or sorrow.

• how can they overcome this.

Share your feelings and suggestions in the class.

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Possible reasons for grief

- Death of a family member, friend or pet
- Serious illness or loss of physical abilities
- Losing a friendship, or moving away from friends
- Failure in an exam or not being chosen as head boy/girl or for the school team
- Problems at home, such as money troubles or quarrels

How to overcome it

- Talk to family, friends or a teacher; do not keep it inside
- Accept that loss and sorrow come to everyone, as Kisa Gotami learnt
- Keep a routine: eat well, sleep, play and exercise
- Take up a hobby, help others, write a diary

- Seek a counsellor's help if the sorrow does not go away

⭐ Writing

1 **Write a paragraph on how you can help others who are in grief. You may consider the following points:**

• grief is expressed through a variety of behaviours — observe these

• reach out to others in their grief, but some people may not want to accept help; some will not share their grief — understand this

• some others will want to talk about their thoughts and feelings — be a support to them, stand by them

• let the grieving person know you care for them — be patient

• focus on what you can do, like holding their hand, etc. — a solace or a consolation

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Helping Others in Grief

Grief is a natural part of life, and every person shows it in a different way. Some people cry, some become silent, and some get angry or stop eating. First, we should carefully observe these signs. Then we should gently reach out to the grieving person. Some people may not want help or may not wish to share their sorrow; we must understand this and give them space. Others want to talk about their thoughts and feelings. For them, we should be good listeners, support them and stand by them. We must let the person know that we care, and be patient, because grief takes time to heal. We need not give long advice. Small things, like holding their hand, sitting beside them, helping with daily work or simply saying 'I am with you', can be a great solace. Kind words and care can help a grieving person slowly find peace again.

2 **Two poems are given in the textbook, First Flight, one by Kahlil Gibran ('Joy and Sorrow'), and the other by Rabindranath Tagore. Read the poems, discuss in groups of four on what these two poets want to say in their respective poems. Then write the summary of each poem and share it with your classmates.**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Summary of 'Joy and Sorrow' by Kahlil Gibran

In this extract from The Prophet, a woman asks the prophet to speak of joy and sorrow. He says that 'your joy is your sorrow unmasked'. The same well from which our laughter rises was often filled with our tears. The deeper sorrow carves into us, the more joy we can hold, just as a cup is burnt in the potter's oven and a lute is hollowed out with knives before it can give pleasure. When we are happy, it is what once gave us sorrow that now gives us joy; when we are sad, we weep for what was once our delight. Joy and sorrow are **inseparable**: they come together, and when one sits with us, the other is asleep on our bed.

Summary of Tagore's lines

Tagore says that when someone dies, we should not say in grief that she is no more. Instead, we should say with **thankfulness** that she was with us. Death is not the putting out of a light for ever; it is like putting out a lamp because **the dawn has come**. So death is not an end but the beginning of a new, brighter life.

What both poets say: sorrow is a part of life; we should accept it calmly and with a positive mind, just as the Buddha taught Kisa Gotami.

Project

1 **Work in groups of four.**

- **Collect Jataka tales (at least six) concerning the previous births of Gautama**

Buddha in both human and animal form.

• Read these and rewrite the stories in your own words. You can develop a comic strip too.

• Make a collage of the stories.

• Illustrate the stories and display the collage in your class.

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Six Jataka tales you can use (from the school library or a book of Jataka tales):

- **The Monkey King (Mahakapi Jataka):** the Bodhisatta as a monkey king makes a bridge of his own body to save his troop.
- **The Golden Deer (Ruru Jataka):** a golden deer saves a drowning man who later betrays him.
- **The Hare in the Moon (Sasa Jataka):** a hare offers its own body as food to a hungry traveller.
- **The Talkative Tortoise (Kacchapa Jataka):** a tortoise falls because it cannot keep its mouth shut.
- **The Elephant and the Dog:** a story of true friendship.
- **The Wise Prince / King Sibi (Sivi Jataka):** a king gives his own flesh to save a dove.

Steps: divide the tales among the group, write each in 8–10 simple sentences, draw 4–6 comic panels per tale, write the moral under each, then paste them on a chart as a collage and display it in class.

🎉 **Chapter 8 done! Revise the answers once more tomorrow.**